

HOW TO BUILD A PORTFOLIO



A PORTFOLIO IS NOT:

✗ AN ARCHIVE

It's not a record of everything you've ever made.

✗ A HISTORY

It's not the chronological history of your work.

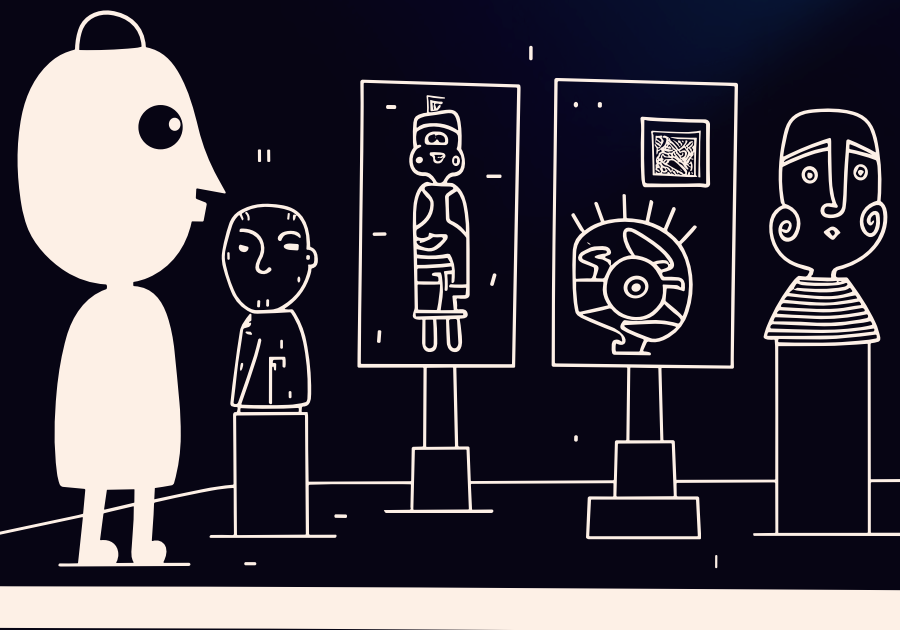
✗ A GREATEST HITS LIST

It's not a greatest hits list of your best projects over the last 15 years without context.

A PORTFOLIO IS:

A portfolio is a designed viewing experience with a beginning, middle, and end.

A portfolio is an **edited selection of your best work**, designed for a specific viewer and purpose.



YOUR PORTFOLIO IS A PORTABLE, TEMPORARY
EXHIBITION OF YOUR CURRENT THINKING.

You are not simply gathering images. You're
constructing an experience.

PUT AUDIENCE AND PURPOSE FIRST

An archive preserves. A portfolio **persuades**.

Your portfolio is a tool that helps others make a decision:
to **invite you, hire you, fund you, exhibit you.**



THE PORTFOLIO CHANGES WITH
THE ASK.



CUSTOMIZE YOUR PORTFOLIO TO YOUR AUDIENCE

You need to **know and research your audience**. Each of these groups has a different set of needs and criteria.

COLLECTING BODIES

- Gallerists
- Museum curators
- Museum acquisition boards
- Art advisors
- Collectors

PROGRAMS

- Admissions committees
- Residency and grant panels
- Awards juries
- Program directors
- Fellowship committees

NON-PROFIT ORGANIZATIONS

- Foundation program officers
- Conference organizers
- Nomination committees
- Non-profit boards

PARTNERS

- Commercial clients
- Potential collaborators
- Fabricators
- Publishers

KEY QUESTION:

WHAT DECISION DO I WANT THEM
TO MAKE AFTER FIVE MINUTES
WITH MY WORK?



SURVIVE FRAGMENTED ATTENTION

The viewer does not encounter your work in neutral space.

They encounter it through the lens of their **own responsibilities and constraints.**

CURATE YOUR PORTFOLIO WITH RECENT WORK

- If the portfolio is an exhibition, then **editing it is a curatorial act**.
- That exhibition shouldn't be a hodge-podge.
- Select work that **speaks in chorus**, with a unified voice.

A PORTFOLIO SHOULD REPRESENT YOUR CURRENT PRACTICE, NOT YOUR ENTIRE HISTORY

The portfolio answers the question: **Who is this artist today?**

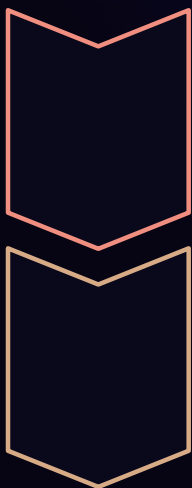
When older work appears, it should feel like part of the same trajectory. Not like an artifact from a different identity.

MOST PORTFOLIOS FUNCTION BEST WHEN THEY INCLUDE:

One or two recent bodies of work in depth.

Possibly one older body of work that clearly leads into them.

What should be avoided is a portfolio that feels like a **timeline of unrelated phases**.



Instead of asking:

How old is this piece?

Ask:

If I made this last month, would I include it?



WHY RECENT WORK MATTERS STRUCTURALLY

01

IT SHOWS WHERE YOUR THINKING IS NOW

Reviewers are investing in your future, not your past. They want to see your **current trajectory**.

02

IT REFLECTS YOUR CURRENT STANDARDS

Your technical and conceptual capacity improves over time.

Older work often reflects earlier limitations. Including it can **weaken the overall presentation**.

03

IT SIGNALS ACTIVE ENGAGEMENT

A portfolio composed mostly of older work raises an implicit concern: *Is this artist still producing at this level?* Recent work answers that question.

GATHER

First, gather **more work than you'll need**.

- Our goal is **10–20 final images**, so pull double that to start.
- Pick from **recent work first**.
- Focus on **bodies of work**, not just single pieces.
- At this stage, add in even new work you're uncertain about.
- **Don't over edit** while gathering.

EDIT

Start by cutting the **weakest 25%**. Remove work that:

- Feels unresolved.
- Depends on too much explanation to function.
- No longer represents you or your thinking.
- You hesitate to show.
- Is poorly documented.

IDENTIFY THE CORE OF YOUR PRACTICE

In the process you should look for:

RECURRING MATERIALS

RECURRING VISUAL LANGUAGE

RECURRING METHODS

RECURRING QUESTIONS

RECURRING EMOTIONAL TONE

These works should form the **through line** of your portfolio.

THE MOST COMMON PORTFOLIO FAILURE IS NOT WEAK WORK.
IT IS A LACK OF COHERENCE AND AN ILLEGIBLE ARTISTIC PRACTICE.

GROUP WORK INTO 2–3 BODIES OR PROJECTS

FEEL INTERNALLY COHERENT

EXPLORE A CLEAR DIRECTION

CONTAIN MULTIPLE WORKS

❏ Avoid isolated single works without context.

EVERY WORK MUST EARN ITS PLACE

Ask of each piece:

- Is this among my **strongest work**?
- Does this **strengthen the overall portfolio** and read of my practice?
- Does this **add something new**?
- What would be lost if it was removed?
- If I were asked why a piece is in here, would I want to defend it?
- If its inclusion shows range, does it risk **fragmenting my voice**?

If not, remove it.

FINAL PORTFOLIO SIZE

10–20

IMAGES TOTAL

Typical range for a complete portfolio submission.

8–15

WORKS

But that may only be 8–15 works, since some may call for including multiple angles.

Quality matters more than quantity.

SEQUENCE LIKE AN EXHIBITION

YOU ARE TELLING A STORY.

Sequence shapes interpretation. Order for maximum clarity.

THINK OF PACING

Think of sequencing in terms of pacing. Like a good exhibition, make sure your portfolio **ebbs and flows**. Vary the rhythm to maintain maximum engagement.



PLACE YOUR STRONGEST WORK FIRST

Your first work should:

Represent your
practice **clearly**

Be **visually
compelling**

Establish
confidence



Avoid warming up slowly.

CREATE VISUAL AND CONCEPTUAL RHYTHM

Alternate:

- Dense / Simple
- Dark / Light
- Large / Small
- Quiet / Complex

If the works start to blur together the viewer will **lose interest**.

AVOID REDUNDANCY

If two works do the same thing include only the stronger one.

Each piece should add something new to the sequence.

END WITH A STRONG CLOSING WORK

Your final work should:

FEEL SIGNIFICANT

FEEL MEMORABLE

SUGGEST DIRECTION

Don't end with a whimper.

TWO SEQUENCING STRUCTURES

How you sequence depends in part on how you make work.



OPTION A: GROUPING BY PROJECT & YEAR

PROJECT A → PROJECT B → PROJECT C

Groupings prioritize **clarity and easy comprehension**. It allows each body of work to establish its internal logic before introducing another. Use this when:

1

The projects are **meaningfully different** from one another.

2

The projects require **immersion** to understand.

3

Changing projects represent **clear transition points** in your practice.

4

You're **earlier in your career**.

5

You're applying to **formal contexts**.

OPTION B: WEAVING BETWEEN IMAGES & TIME PERIODS

2026 → 2026 → 2023 → 2024 → 2022 → 2021 → 2022, ETC.

This structure prioritizes **connections**. It allows the viewer to see the relationships you want to draw between bodies of work. Use this when:

1

The projects share the **same goals and questions**.

2

The pieces are **conceptually interdependent**.

3

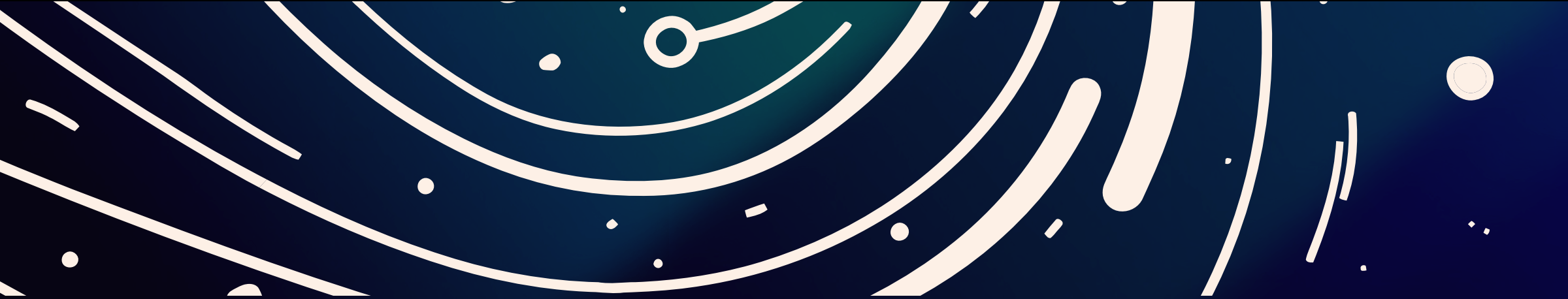
You want to emphasize the **integrated nature** of your practice.

4

The **visual dialogue** between works strengthens each.

5

Your practice is **highly cohesive** even across mediums.



Early-career artists should generally favor grouping by project and year.

More established artists can use weaving to communicate cohesion and depth.

WEAVING IS MORE PRONE TO FAILURE

Weaving is **structurally more demanding**. You're adding complexity, which assumes the work can sustain that complexity.

It requires consistency across your practice. If the relationship between projects isn't immediately clear, the portfolio will feel chaotic. And you risk confusing reviewers, which makes your application an **easy no**.

In contrast, grouping by project is less likely to produce confusion.

Grouping's risks are different. It can make your art practice feel **compartmentalized** if you don't have clear connections between your bodies of work.

A SIMPLE TEST

Does this work need to stand on its own to be understood?

If yes, group by project and year.

Does this work become clearer when seen in close connection with another?

If yes, weaving images and time-periods may be more appropriate.

SIX ADDITIONAL SEQUENCING STRATEGIES

1 CHRONOLOGICAL

Useful when you want to communicate growth.

2 INQUIRY AND EXPANSION

Present one body of work as the foundation and the next as its expansion.

3 THEMATIC/CONCEPTUAL

Show how an idea evolves across projects.

4 MATERIAL

Connect your practice together through the questions each medium unlocks.

5 NARRATIVE FRAME

Tell a story in four acts: hook, deepen, pivot, resolve.

6 ANCHOR AND SATELLITES

Open with a central work, then present a constellation of supporting works.

WHEN DO TWO MEDIUMS BELONG IN THE SAME PORTFOLIO?

When they feel like **different manifestations of the same inquiry**.

The medium shifts. The investigation remains stable.

Example: An artist making paintings about fragmented architectural space, as well as sculptures with fragmented architectural forms is clearly engaged in the same set of questions, even though the medium changes.

FORMAT

Eventually, you should have:

- a PDF for sending and applying
- a simple website for browsing

Both are necessary.

PDF VS. WEBSITE

PDFs allow you to:

- Control sequence
- Tailor to specific opportunities
- Send directly

Websites allow viewers to:

- Browse freely based on their interests
- Explore your work with a sense of discovery

DESIGN BASICS

✓ INCLUDE:

- Consistent formatting
- Clear labelling
- Readable type
- Generally one image per page
- Manageable file size

✗ AVOID:

- Decorative graphics
- Complex layouts

📄 The work should be the focus.

PORTFOLIO DESIGN SOFTWARE

- Adobe InDesign
- Adobe Lightroom (for photographers)
- Affinity Publisher
- Figma
- Canva
- PowerPoint / Keynote / Google Slides

FILE NAMING MATTERS

Make sure a reviewer can tell:

A red rounded rectangular box, likely representing a field for file naming information.

Who the work is from

An orange rounded rectangular box, likely representing a field for file naming information.

What order it should be viewed in

A blue rounded rectangular box, likely representing a field for file naming information.

What this PDF is for or applies to

FILE NAMING CONVENTIONS

- Always start with your **name**.
- Include the word **Portfolio**.
- If you're uploading images number them **01, 02, 03**, etc.
- Perhaps include the **title of the projects** or individual pieces, and the year.
- Consider including the **name of the opportunity**.

Name_Portfolio_01.jpg

Name_Portfolio_01-Title(Year).jpg

EXAMPLE:

Haiver_Portfolio_01.jpg

Haiver_Portfolio_01-InTheWaysOfBeing(2023).jpg

⌀

Name_Portfolio_ResidencyName.pdf

EXAMPLE:

Haiver_Portfolio_StJohnsCollegeResidency.pdf

⌀

Avoid: Name_Portfolio_Title_01.jpg

EXAMPLE:

Haiver-Portfolio-AlwaysOn-04.jpg

Haiver-Portfolio-AlwaysOn-05.jpg

Haiver-Portfolio-InTheWaysOfBeing-01.jpg

Haiver-Portfolio-InTheWaysOfBeing-02.jpg

Haiver-Portfolio-InTheWaysOfBeing-03.jpg

WITHIN YOUR PDF, EVERY WORK NEEDS A CAPTION

Include:

Title

Year

Medium

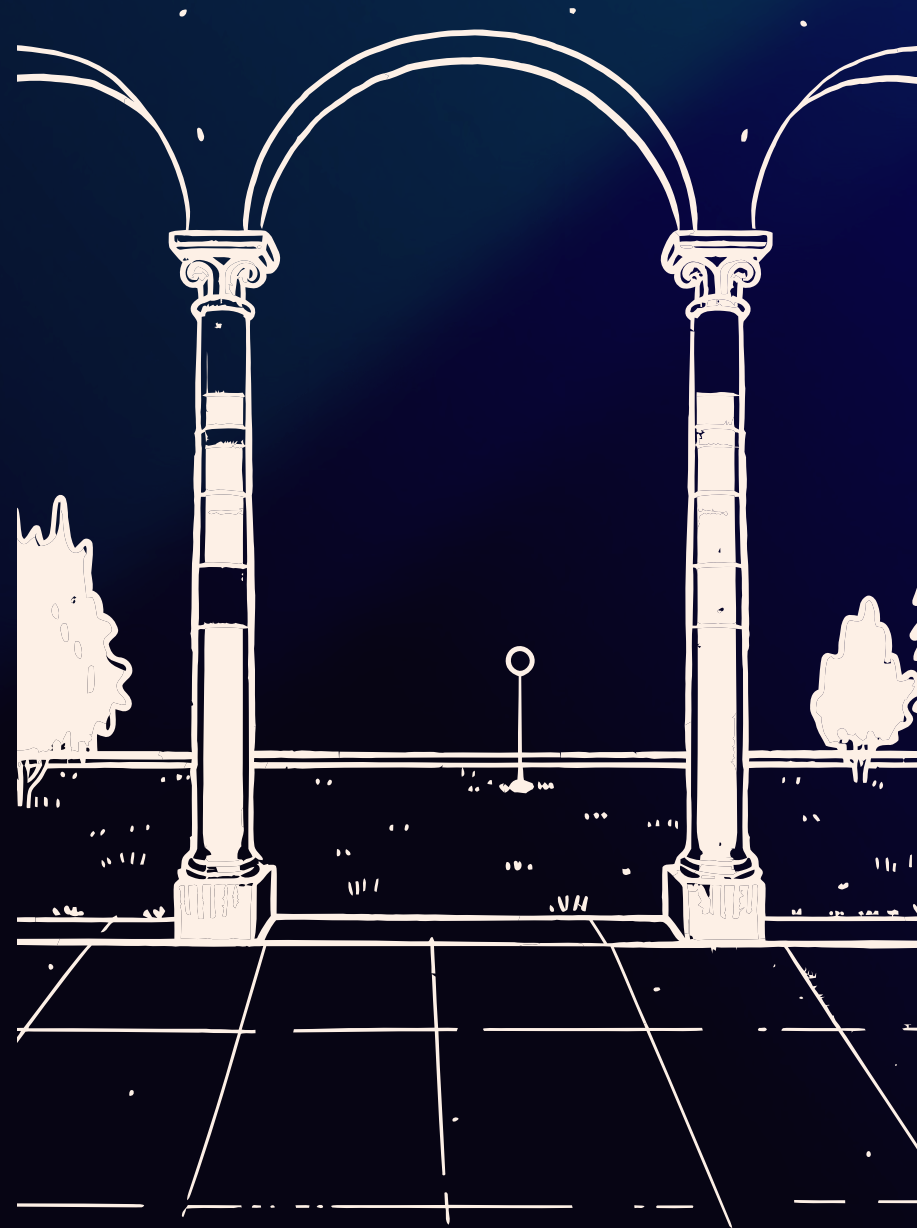
Dimensions

USE A CONSISTENT CAPTIONING FORMAT

Untitled, 2024

Oil on canvas

48 × 36 inches



TITLES HELP IDENTIFY WORK

Titles can be:



Descriptive



Abstract



Untitled

Each is acceptable. But **avoid leaving works completely unnamed.**

DIMENSIONS HELP THE VIEWER UNDERSTAND SCALE

Always include:



HEIGHT FIRST



THEN WIDTH



THEN DEPTH (IF APPLICABLE)

Example: **24 × 18 × 12 inches**

MEDIUM SHOULD BE SPECIFIC

✗ INSTEAD OF:

Mixed media

✓ USE:

Oil, acrylic, and graphite on canvas

📄 Be precise.

KEEP WRITING MINIMAL IN THE PORTFOLIO ITSELF

Portfolio captions should **identify**.

Not explain.



STRONG DOCUMENTATION

DOCUMENTATION SHOULD AVOID SABOTAGING
THE WORK.

PRIORITIZE CLARITY ABOVE ALL ELSE

Your photographic or scanned documentation should be:

✓ SHOULD BE:

- Sharp
- Evenly lit
- Properly exposed
- Color accurate
- Undistorted

✗ AVOID:

- Blurry images
- Dramatic shadows
- Tilted or skewed framing

PHOTOGRAPHY BASICS

FOR 2D WORK:

- Camera parallel to the surface
- No angle distortion
- Crop cleanly

✗ AVOID:

- Perspective distortion
- Photographing from above (e.g. creating shadows)

SHOW ONLY WHAT HELPS THE VIEWER UNDERSTAND THE WORK

- Full View
- Detail Views (if needed)
- Installation View (if relevant)

THE FOCUS SHOULD BE ONLY ON THE WORK

So, remove all distractions. Avoid showing:

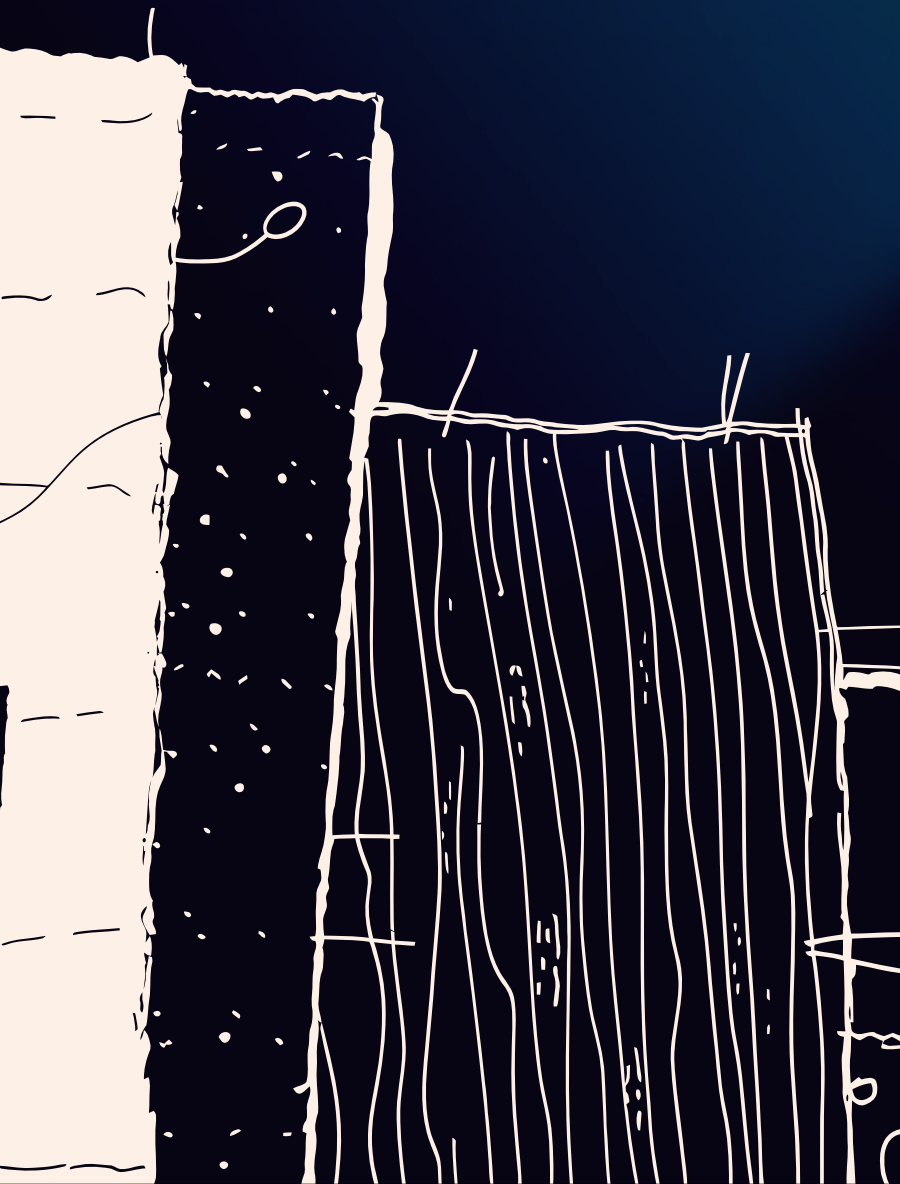
- Studio Clutter
- Wall Damage
- Uneven Backgrounds
- Objects Not Part of the Work

MAINTAIN CONSISTENCY ACROSS ALL DOCUMENTATION IMAGES

Your portfolio should feel **unified**.

Images should feel:

- Consistent in Framing
- Consistent in Color Cast
- Consistent in Lighting



THE ROLE OF DETAIL & INSTALLATION IMAGES

INSTALLATION SHOTS REVEAL:

SCALE

SPATIAL INTELLIGENCE

EXHIBITION READINESS

Especially important for:

- Sculpture
- Installation
- Interdisciplinary Work
- Large-Scale Work

WHEN TO INCLUDE INSTALLATION SHOTS

✓ INCLUDE WHEN THEY SHOW HOW THE WORK:

- Occupies or activates a space
- Changes the environment
- Affects a viewer's perception

✗ AVOID WHEN THEY:

- Distract from the work
- Make the work harder to see
- Introduce visual clutter

📄 The installation shot should clarify, not obscure.

DETAIL SHOTS REVEAL:

FORMAL PRECISION

PERCEPTUAL DEPTH

MATERIAL INTELLIGENCE

Especially important for:

- Painting
- Drawing
- Sculpture
- Textile
- Mixed Media

DETAIL SHOTS MIGHT INCLUDE:



BRUSHWORK



SURFACE TEXTURE



LAYERING



JOINS AND SEAMS



EDGE CONDITIONS



TRANSITIONS BETWEEN MATERIALS

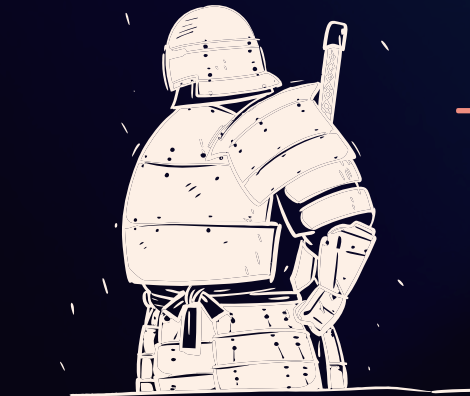
A TYPICAL STRUCTURE MIGHT INCLUDE:

FULL VIEW

Overall composition showing complete assembly.

INSTALLATION VIEW

Spatial context and placement in situ.



DETAIL VIEW

Close-up precision of critical features.

Each contributes different information.

STRONG PORTFOLIOS SOMETIMES BREAK CONVENTIONS

OPEN WITH QUIET WORK

INCLUDE UNCONVENTIONAL
DOCUMENTATION

USE UNUSUAL SEQUENCING

❏ But only when those decisions **strengthen understanding**.



MAINTAINING YOUR PORTFOLIO

- Review and Update Regularly.
- Replace Weak Work as Stronger Work Emerges.
- Do Not Add Work. Replace Work.
- Most Strong Portfolios Are Revised Constantly.

THE FULL PORTFOLIO PACKAGE

Typically includes:



Portfolio PDF (images)



Artist Statement



Artist Bio



CV



Contact Information